

Ashwini Vaishnaw
Minister of Railways

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Manufacturing 400 Vande Bharat train sets to run on 75 routes by August 15 next year
- Push new PPP model to enable private capital to join hands with Railways to manufacture modern locomotives, coaches and other rolling stock
- Continue structural reforms to improve decision-making at the railways board
- Retain confidence of rail unions

six months, Kavach has been rolled out on the New Delhi-Howrah and New Delhi-Mumbai sections and is targeted for completion by March 2024. Thirdly, he won the confidence of the unions by committing that private capital will come in only into capacity-building, and the units will not be corporatised. Further, his understanding of technology and the skills picked up during his corporate jobs came in handy while designing a new PPP model, where private capital is sought to upgrade the existing facilities to manufacture rolling stocks, with investors allowed to take existing railway staff on deputation in their operations at these units.

The idea is to enhance their skill sets for future-ready technologies. This model has also cut down the capital expenditure requirements from the corporates. The railways has already started the process to select the partners for manufacturing 800 high-end electric 12,000 HP locomotives for freight carriage and modern LHB (Linke Hoffmann Busch) coaches at their existing factories.

The biggest test for Vaishnaw will be realising the dream of running 400 indigenously designed and developed semi-high speed Vande Bharat trains on existing tracks in the next three years. He says the prototypes will be ready by August and, based on their trials, commercial production will start in the next 45 days. His mid-term goal is to run these trains on 75 routes by Independence Day next year.

The train sets—self-propelled locomotives linked together with the coaches to form a unified set—will ensure a more comfortable ride than premium trains like the Rajdhani and Shatabdi. By Diwali, the railways is expected to get 4-5 trains every month, to run on some routes connecting Ahmedabad, Delhi, Lucknow, Bhopal, Guwahati, Kolkata, Tirupati, Pune, Chennai etc. Currently, Vande Bharat trains are running on the Delhi-Katra and Delhi-Lucknow routes. ■